

Client Background

This number grew and expanded into multiple locations around Santa Barbara County. Rusty's unique name first came from the fact that it started as a restaurant that sold roast beef and wore the title of "Rusty's Roast Beef."¹ Before founding Rusty's, the then owners, Roger and Carol Duncan, worked in local grocery stores, with Roger Duncan being the manager of a local grocery store and his wife being an elementary school teacher. Hungry for a way to provide for their two daughters, Roger and Carol saw that there was a space needed for a local pizza company since there was none at the time to bring their kids to. This led to Rusty's name being combined with the words "pizza parlor" and the rest is history. This has put Rusty's pizza on the map as a family-friendly place where families can come together and enjoy quality pizza and arcade games, especially following the opening of their next two locations in Upper State Street and North Milpas. Rusty's focus on family has contributed to the fact that they have been around for so long. In the 1970s, famous artist Frank Webb held free drawing and art classes at Rusty's State Street location, allowing families to spend quality time together.² During this time, Rusty's even hosted movie nights, which back then were in black and white, including famous films such as Felix the Cat and Charlie Chaplin films, too. This history proves just how invested in the community families they were, and since family has always been a huge focus of Rusty's, the Duncan family also currently runs this business. Recently, Rusty's Pizza has finally returned to its original location in Isla Vista with the same mission in mind for its residents, providing top-quality food for people to come together to enjoy and a community to make meaningful university memories.

Today, Rusty's key players in the organization keep Roger and Carol Duncan's vision alive by staying committed to the family-founded business that Rusty's is. Currently, the Duncan name and bloodline remain strong within Rusty's organization, as Tyler Duncan serves as the current CEO and President of Rusty's Pizza.³ Alongside his wife, Whitney Duncan, and the help of their staff, Rusty's Pizza works hard to provide fresh hot pizza every time for local families. With the help of their hardworking staff, Rusty's Pizza is proud to provide the local population with jobs at all 8 locations. They truly concern themselves with how they can contribute to the community that they love. With a value on loyalty, many of the employees that Rusty's has are long-time employees. Many of the delivery drivers working there have been with this company

¹ Rusty's Pizza Parlor, "Our Story," accessed January 2026, <https://rustyspizza.com/about/>

² Rusty's Pizza Parlor, "About Us," accessed January 2026, <https://rustyspizza.com/about/>.

³ Tyler Duncan, LinkedIn profile, accessed January 2026, <https://www.linkedin.com/in/tylerduncan/>

for many years. This is crucial as it is just as important who made the pizza as who is delivering it to people, without the worry of shady third-party delivery drivers tampering with a product someone purchases.

As Santa Barbara's main place to get a high-quality, affordable pizza, Rusty's Pizza has values that are crucial to their whole mission as a business. Rooted in the reason that Rusty's was founded by Roger and Carol Duncan, the family has been a huge focus for Rusty's since the beginning. They pride themselves on being the place that people first think about when they think of where they should take their kids on an evening out or in. It has been solidified as a staple comfort food for those who grew up in Santa Barbara. It is hard to find someone living in Santa Barbara who doesn't know about Rusty's Pizza, due to their heavy involvement in the community. Family and community remain the core values of Rusty's Pizza Parlor.⁴ Their dedication to providing a safe space for the Santa Barbara Community is so strong that they have a whole portion of their website for community outreach, where one can petition for a donation from their organization. Rusty's also partners with large organizations across Santa Barbara County, including the Santa Barbara Zoo, the Santa Barbara Unified School District, and the Scholarship Foundation of Santa Barbara.⁵ Rusty's Pizza often shows a strong presence at many of the local festivals and events that happen locally, such as the Lemon Fest, a huge festival that takes place annually in Golet, where families can come together to enjoy the incredible community that this city has to offer. Not to mention that Rusty's has their Storke Rd. location across the street from where the Lemon Fest takes place. Since Rusty's has such a strong care for the Santa Barbara community, they pride themselves on the quality of their ingredients as well. This is something that has never changed for Rusty's, as to this day, the dough, the cheese, and the sauce are always made fresh in-house every day. Each Rusty's location also features a salad bar in which these ingredients are always fresh and locally sourced. In addition to this, Rusty's prides themselves on how fast they can deliver a hot, fresh pizza every time to every customer. This is made possible primarily due to the number of locations they have and their drive to deliver quality. This commitment to quality and reliability is a major reason customers continue to return to Rusty's, as they do not expect to receive cold pizza after long wait times.⁶ Ultimately, Rusty's is an organization that provides value to the Santa Barbara community and continues to

⁴ Rusty's Pizza Parlor, "About Us," accessed January 2026, <https://rustyspizza.com/about/>

⁵ Rusty's Pizza Parlor, "Community Outreach," accessed January 2026, <https://rustyspizza.com/community-outreach/>.

⁶ Alice Harter, Lucas Stich & Martin Spann, "The Impact of Delivery Time on Customer Satisfaction in Food Service," *Journal of Services Marketing*, accessed January 2026, <https://journals.sagepub.com/doi/abs/10.1177/10946705241236961>

do so by providing a space where everyone in town is welcome while still giving back to the people of the city.

Key Products and Services

Rusty's is known for their quality pizzas, their team explained that the reason for their 10 different store locations around Santa Barbara is to ensure providing quality and hot pizza to every corner of Santa Barbara. With this Isla Vista location being at the heart of downtown Isla Vista, Rusty's plans to sell not just quality food but an experience. The cheesy pizza (of which you can choose several toppings from) and ranch sauce that tastes like no other will work as a reliable food source for college students wanting efficient and good food. The outside balcony and brick-warm interior allow the location to keep a fun, safe, and nostalgic environment for college students and residential families. According to their website, Rusty's provides delivery service until midnight on Fridays and Saturdays and until 11 pm for the rest of the week. They share the amenities of a large street-front patio, big screen TVs, pizza by the slice, and quick lunch. Our team will work closely with Rusty's to upgrade their patio space into an entertainment area that would hold a photobooth and work as the Karaoke Night stage.

Current Communication/Marketing Efforts

At present, Rusty's Pizza Parlor engages in a mix of traditional and digital marketing efforts that emphasize value, familiarity, and community connection.⁷ Current promotional strategies include email marketing campaigns featuring discount codes, limited but ongoing direct mail promotions, and an active but light TikTok presence. Rusty's also participates in community-targeted promotions such as gift card programs and local support initiatives, reinforcing its role as a community-oriented business. Additionally, the brand has shown openness to expanding student-focused efforts through potential student discounts, local events, and beer promotions, particularly relevant for its Isla Vista location and surrounding college population.

Rusty's visual branding is nostalgic and tradition-driven, aligning with broader restaurant industry trends where familiarity and comfort resonate strongly with the younger generations.⁸ The brand presents itself as casual and community-focused rather than trendy or exclusive, using the long-standing identity to evoke trust and emotional connection. Rusty's also emphasizes

⁷ Rusty's Pizza Parlor, "Media," accessed January 2026, <https://rustypizza.com/media/#3OBqn8URZKQ>.

⁸ Modern Restaurant Management, "What Recession Pop Reveals About Nostalgia in the Restaurant Industry," accessed January 2026, <https://modernrestaurantmanagement.com/what-recession-pop-reveals-about-nostalgia-in-the-restaurant-industry/>.

inclusivity by fostering a welcoming environment by bringing all together to enjoy their time and pizza. Through its messages, Rusty communicates a community-first message that highlights togetherness, local togetherness, and approachability. The main message focuses on shared experiences, freshness, and being a reliable gathering place. This tone supports the brand's family-friendly reputation while also resonating with college students who value relaxed social environments. By continuing to highlight bringing the community together, while also incorporating more student-specific promotions, Rusty's communication branding can further strengthen its appeal to the college demographic.

Buyer Personas

Rusty's Pizza Parlor is mainly looking for college students who want to spend time with friends in a relaxed, social environment. While society emphasizes partying and going out, many prefer environments that let them socialize without feeling overwhelmed.⁹ They enjoy being out and having a social life, but are not always interested in crowded and loud spaces. Instead, they look for places where they can talk comfortably, enjoy their food, and hang out with friends for as long as needed. Another important persona for Rusty's is the families integrated in Isla Vista, who live there year-round, unlike college students. Rusty's Pizza Parlor meets this need by offering a casual, group-friendly environment. A safe place to relax and connect without pressure, making it easier for friends and family to gather.

Primary Target Audiences

At the moment, Rusty's Pizza Parlor primarily serves families and has a high emphasis on community. Its current audience includes parents with children, long-term residents, and alumni who view Rusty's as a familiar and dependable gathering place. These customers are drawn to the brand's casual atmosphere, consistent food quality, and group-friendly layout, making it a reliable option for family dinners and social meals. However, in a college town like Santa Barbara, especially in a location like Isla Vista, the most relevant and strategic primary target audience is college students. Isla Vista has a very young population, with a median age of 21. While many students participate in nightlife, this environment also creates demand for alternative social spaces that are calmer and more comfortable.¹⁰

⁹ Modern Restaurant Management, "What Recession Pop Reveals About Nostalgia in the Restaurant Industry," accessed January 2026, <https://modernrestaurantmanagement.com/what-recession-pop-reveals-about-nostalgia-in-the-restaurant-industry/>.

¹⁰ U.S. Census Bureau, "Isla Vista CDP, California," *Census Reporter*, accessed January 2026, <https://censusreporter.org/profiles/16000US0636868-isla-vista-ca/>

Demographically, college students wanting a good time without exhausting themselves physically, mentally, and emotionally. Psychographically, the students who value social connection, affordability, and a relaxed environment. Audiences that enjoy spending time with friends, but are not always interested in loud or crowded social settings. Instead, they look for places that feel welcoming to groups, allow them to stay for extended periods, and do not pressure them to be overly energetic or spend excessively. Rusty's Pizza Parlor meets these needs through its casual seating, shareable pizza format, and accessible pricing, positioning it as an ideal social space for college students who want a fun, low-pressure environment to connect with friends.

Secondary Target Audiences

Apart from UCSB students, Rusty's Pizza hopes to gain regulars from alumni and families who live around the Goleta area. Because Rusty's pizza revolves around the family field, expanding this audience would serve as a substitute for customers when UCSB students are not in school. This includes the families living in the area, or people coming into Isla Vista during the summer when students leave. Rusty's wants to be that place people go to when they want to taste a piece of Isla Vista when visiting or the place they come back to when they return to Isla Vista.

Primary Competitors

Three of the organization's biggest competitors are Woodstock's, Pizza Pub, and Domino's - all located in Isla Vista as well. Domino's Pizza is at the heart of Isla Vista, which makes it an easy location for anyone who lives in IV. This Domino's is open until three in the morning, which gives many of the UCSB students a chance to head to Domino's after a late night out or a late night study. They also allow their customers to build their own pizza to make it how they want it and give them a chance to customize their cravings.

IV pizza pub (quality, taste, good market), family history, complementary hot honey to attract customers, added pitchers to the menu to attract more of the younger crowd, persistence on outreach through social media (Harmon, 2025). This restaurant is said to offer fresh ingredients as well and has won awards for being a great pizza for college students. They also have the big sign in front of the restaurant that says they have been voted #1 for a few years in a row now.¹¹

Woodstock's being the top competitor in Isla Vista for being the main attraction for UCSB students because they offer different discounts and events has made it difficult for Rusty's

¹¹ IV Pizza Pub, "About," accessed January 2026, <https://ivpizzapub.com/about/>.

to stand out. This restaurant has become a collaborator with sporting events at UCSB, offering free slices when sports win their games at home, and also includes a smaller location on campus, making it very accessible for students when they are at home or on campus. Woodstucks also offers delivery services with different price ranges, the further you are from Santa Barbara.¹²

Although these other competitors are more popular, Rusty's is a place where they can offer you a pizza made with real, rich ingredients to ensure you are eating a good slice, and even have ingredients imported straight from Italy. Their ranch is a sensation at the restaurant and a staple of their menu, ensuring that everything eaten is made from real ingredients. This location also offers quick delivery to you, which means you will still have your hot pizza for you as opposed to other locations that turn out to be cold by the time they reach your home. There is also the nostalgia of video games at the locations, which adds the feature of having fun while enjoying a pizza with your friends or family. With Rusty's history when creating Rusty's, there was a space needed for a local pizza company since there was none at the time to bring their kids too, this place can also bring families to one place to spend time together and parents can also be the place in Isla Vista to offer a family friendly environment as opposed to other competitors who don't have that scene in their restaurants.

Client Communication Challenge (CCC)

Rusty's faces a series of problems in the race for marketing success in their new Isla Vista location. While they face serious competitors in the game, they also face the challenge of not being able to reach their primary target audience, the college students of UCSB. While their typical marketing strategy has been effective in their other locations, this particular location operates slightly differently. Unfortunately, Rusty's traditional marketing prioritizes families and older age groups that value the sit-down experience. For the party-crazy students of Isla Vista, that can be very incompatible. Their competitors have the edge when it comes to integrating themselves into college culture. So they aren't just competing on taste; they are competing on brand loyalty, convenience, and economic accessibility. For a company like Woodstock's that has been operating for forty years, Rusty's has only been open since March. When students come to live in Isla Vista, chances are they've heard about Woodstock's before they even arrive. Rusty's must build its own unique reputation to capture the students of Isla Vista.

¹² Woodstock's Pizza Isla Vista, "Delivery," accessed January 2026, <https://woodstocksiv.com/>.

Unfortunately, Isla Vista has a strict noise ordinance that is enforced from 10 pm to 7 am on weekdays and from 12 am to 7 am on weekends.¹³ In addition, any sound loud at distances greater than 50 feet can result in a fine or misdemeanor. Even if they were to host parties earlier, they may be directly competing with Woodstock's events. The challenge is deciding what type of events would attract students, while also considering the timing, marketing for said events, and what they want their brand to be known for. Whether or not they follow a similar path like Woodstocks, they need to find a unique personality that best suits their business.

Time is also a very important factor that is hard to dismiss. For busy college students, time is money, and the immediate gratification of picking up something on the way becomes a very valuable currency. Where Rusty's is normally ready within 15-20 minutes, their competitors utilize their fast food advantages. This model becomes perceived as easy and available, allowing for a continuous revenue of students. For Rusty's, the slower time component can limit its image to "weekends only" and a "special occasion"-type meal. In addition, the likelihood of a consumer choosing another option increases exponentially when there is a built-up line. In fact, 69% of people within Generation Z report using a third-party food service to explicitly avoid the time-element.¹⁴

But the issue becomes slightly more difficult when you take into account the economic means of the area. Students in Isla Vista simply can not afford the "high quality, high price" of Rusty's. Rusty's is used to the family model consumers who tend to have a greater economic footing and security. The contrast is that college students are entering that awkward stage in their lives where they are becoming more independent from their parents. For example, the median household income in Isla Vista is only \$28,428, making an astounding poverty rate of 69.3%.¹⁵ Additionally, 42% of UC students were surveyed as food insecure, with 19% with very low food security.¹⁶ For a demographic that has a limited budget to spend on pizza, Rusty's must make their prices feel like a necessary investment. Rusty's has the advantage of homemade preparation

¹³ Santa Barbara County Sheriff's Office, "Isla Vista Foot Patrol Ordinance Changes 2024," accessed January 2026, <https://www.sbsheriff.org/wp-content/uploads/2024/01/IVFP-Ordinance-Changes-2024.pdf>.

¹⁴ PYMNTS, "Gen Z 4x More Likely to Use Food Delivery Services Than Boomers," accessed January 2026, <https://www.pymnts.com/news/delivery/2023/gen-z-4x-more-likely-to-use-food-delivery-services-than-boomers/>.

¹⁵ World Population Review, "Isla Vista, California," accessed January 2026, <https://worldpopulationreview.com/us-cities/california/isla-vista>.

¹⁶ UCSB Basic Needs Program, "Food Security Accomplishments and Ongoing Programs," July 2023, accessed January 2026, https://basicneeds.ucsb.edu/sites/default/files/2023-07/food-security-accomplishments-and-ongoing-programs_v2.pdf.

and quality ingredients; there just needs to be a way to fully leverage their strengths. So, it's not necessarily a pricing problem, but more a communication and marketing issue.

Solutions

Aiming to enhance Rusty's Pizza Parlor brand towards college students, there are a few approaches for the CCC. The main plan that sets the rest of the solutions is rebranding the business in town for those college students. Given the fact that Rusty's pride themselves on creating a strong sense of community, fun, and nostalgia, this would still apply to students.¹⁷ An additional solution would be finding ways to alter the menu prices to make them "cheaper." Even incorporating deals, such as discounted events, would attract customers. This approach would appeal to the student population, since the main concern for them is price.

Likewise, one thing to keep in mind about being in a college town is that there are fewer people during the summer, as students tend to go home for break. Due to the decrease in the student population, this would lead to slow foot traffic and little profit. As mentioned in an earlier section, having a secondary target audience (families) can be a substitute audience during the summer. Rusty's Pizza Parlor would be able to maintain its sales and profit if the menu included items, such as family/kids meals that are specifically promoted for families. A last solution would be to find ways to involve the community and UCSB to widen exposure. For example, involving the student community, it would involve collaborating with campus organizations and sports. Not only would this be beneficial for students' fundraising and bringing attention to Rusty's, but this would also help strengthen relationships between the brand and customers. Overall, these solutions cover various aspects of the CCC.

Regarding these proposed solutions, we believe they will directly solve the client's problem. As we narrowed down the target audience beyond just students, this will allow Rusty's to communicate more effectively and drive further sales. Having variety in the brand's marketing messages can expand its presence in Isla Vista. This includes tailoring the brand to better fit college students and families for reasons like affordability, convenience, and social gatherings. In addition to that, some possible metrics for assessing the success of these solutions are foot

¹⁷ Entegra Procurement Services, "Making Hospitality Inclusive Is Easier Than You Think," accessed January 2026, <https://www.entegraps.com/articles-and-insights/news-and-insights/making-hospitality-inclusive-easier-you-think>.

traffic, sales, event turnouts, and having a strong social media presence.¹⁸ All of these metrics tie in with each other in building up brand growth and customer loyalty for Rusty's Pizza Parlor.

¹⁸ Altametrics, "Social Media Marketing Plan," accessed January 2026, <https://altametrics.com/social-media-marketing-plan.html>.